

LESSON 10

Topic: Charity — The Heart of the Christian Life

Text: **1 Corinthians 13:1–13; Colossians 3:14; Luke 10:25–37**

Aim: Understanding biblical charity (agape love) not merely as an act of giving, but as the foundational nature of God, the highest expression of our faith, and our primary witness to the world.

Introduction

In modern culture, the word "charity" has been reduced to the act of donating money or goods to those in need. While giving is certainly part of it, the biblical concept of charity reaches far deeper. In the original Greek of the New Testament, the word used is agape a selfless, unconditional love that seeks the good of others without any expectation of return. It is not a feeling that comes and goes; it is a decision, a commitment, and ultimately a reflection of God's own character.

Charity is not done for recognition or applause. It is not merely an occasional act of generosity. It is a lifestyle produced by a heart transformed by God. True charity gives without pride, serves without seeking reward, and loves even when it is inconvenient. It sees people the way God sees them and responds with mercy.

The Apostle Paul, writing to the church in Corinth, placed charity above every spiritual gift. A person may speak in tongues, prophesy, move mountains through faith, or give their entire fortune to the poor yet without charity, Paul declares it all amounts to nothing. Charity is not one virtue among many; it is the environment in which every other virtue flourishes.

This lesson calls us to examine our hearts honestly. It is easy to perform acts of kindness from a place of pride, obligation, or public recognition. True charity, however, operates quietly, sacrificially, and joyfully not because the recipient deserves it, but because God first loved us and poured His love into our hearts through the Holy Spirit (**Romans 5:5**).

KEY IDEAS

1. The Nature of True Charity

(1 Corinthians 13:4–7; Romans 5:8)

Paul's famous description of charity in **1 Corinthians 13** is not primarily a poem it is a mirror. It shows us what divine love looks like in practice: patient, kind, not envious, not boastful, not self-seeking, not easily angered, keeping no record of wrongs. Each of these qualities stands in direct opposition to the natural human inclination toward self-preservation and self-promotion.

2. Charity Should Be a Lifestyle for Every Believer

(Galatians 6:9–10; Hebrews 13:16)

Charity is not for a selected few; it is for every Christian. Believers are called to do good to all people, especially to fellow believers. A charitable life includes helping the poor, encouraging the weak, supporting the work of God, visiting the sick, and caring for people in distress. Charity should become part of everyday Christian living, not just an occasional religious duty.

Charity in Action — The Good Samaritan

(Luke 10:30–37; James 2:14–17)

The parable of the Good Samaritan demolishes every excuse for inaction. The priest and the Levite both religious men saw the wounded man and passed by. The Samaritan, considered an outsider and an enemy by the Jewish audience, stopped, sacrificed his time, resources, and comfort, and ensured the man's full recovery.

Jesus' closing words "Go and do likewise" are a direct commission to every believer. Charity is not theoretical compassion; it is boots-on-the-ground action in response to human need. James reinforces this: faith without works is dead. Charity that remains in the heart but never reaches the hands is not biblical charity at all.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- 1. What do you understand in your personal thoughts about charity, is it different from generosity?**
 - a. How can we distinguish between giving out of obligation or social pressure and giving out of genuine love (agape)?**
- 2. How can we show charity to people who are not obviously in need**
 - a. What false teachings has twisted the true meaning of charity in today's church?**
- 3. What challenges do believers encounter when expressing charity to others?**
 - a. How can we show charity to those who are ungrateful, unkind, or even our enemies, as suggested in **Luke 6:35-36**?**
 - b. You can give without loving, but you can never love without giving." Do you agree or disagree with this statement? Why?**
- 4. What are the benefits of practicing true charity faithfully until the end? **Peter 4:8**;**
 - a. What kind of sacrifices may be required for a believer to live a life of charity today?**
 - b. What are some wrong motives people may have for giving or helping others?**
- 5. How can believers guard their hearts to ensure that their giving and service flow from genuine love rather than performance or obligation?**
 - a. How can the local church model and cultivate a culture of charity not just in fundraising drives, but in the everyday relationships within the congregation?**

Memory Verse

Matthew 22:37-40, John 4:7-11